William Johnston

Curriculum Vitae

Département de linguistique
Université du Québec à Montréal
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Education

Ph.D, 2024 — Linguistics, McGill University
Dissertation: *Event structure and serial verbs in Hmong.*
Supervisors: Jessica Coon and Luis Alonso-Ovalle.

B.A., 2013 — Linguistics, Carleton College (Northfield, MN)
2012 Off Campus Study: Linguistics and Culture in Japan
Doshisha University, Kyoto

Employment

2024–Present — Postdoctoral researcher, Université du Québec à Montréal
Fonds de recherche du Québec (FRQ) Postdoctoral Fellowship
Supervisor: Richard Compton.

2025–2026 — Parental leave

2024 — Course Lecturer, Université du Québec à Montréal

2023 — Course Lecturer, McGill University

2021 — Course Lecturer, McGill University

Research

Grants & Fellowships

Fonds de recherche du Québec (FRQ) Postdoctoral Fellowship, 2024–2027.
Syntactic categories in White Hmong: Implications for linguistic theory and language education | Les catégories syntaxiques en hmong blanc: implications pour la théorie linguistique et l'enseignement des langues. $90,000.

Journal Articles

Johnston, W. (2023). "Pair-list answers to questions with plural definites." *Semantics and Pragmatics* 16(2).

Conference Proceedings

Johnston, W. (2025). "Decomposing Path: Deprepositional verbs in White Hmong" *Proceedings of the 42nd West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 42)*.

Johnston, W. (2025). "Culmination entailments in V and P: Evidence from White Hmong." *Proceedings of the 41st West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 41)*.

Johnston, W. (2024). "Two diagnostics for preposition-hood: Decomposing Path in White Hmong." *Proceedings of the 14th Generative Linguistics in the Old World in Asia (GLOW in Asia XIV)*.

Johnston, W. (2022). "Nonspecific promises: The Intensional Restitution Effect." *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung 26*.

Johnston, W. (2019). "Pair-list questions from dependent plurals." *Proceedings of the 22nd Amsterdam Colloquium*.

Manuscripts

Johnston, W. (Resubmitted). "Paths across worlds: the presupposition of 'back' in intensional contexts."

Johnston, W. (In revision). "Causation and serialization in White Hmong."

Johnston, W. (Submitted). "(De)prepositional motion predicates: The path spine in Hmong."

Johnston, W. and H.L. Soh (In preparation). "Clausal Complementation, Finiteness and Object Control in Hmong."

Invited Talks

"Causation and serialization in Hmong." *Converging on Causal Ontology Analyses*. Centre national de la recherche scientifique (CNRS), Paris. Oct. 11, 2024.

"Path in Hmong: The structure of directional PPs." *Annual Conference of the Canadian Linguistic Association*. Carleton University, Ottawa. June 19, 2024.

"The verb phrase in Hmong: Serialization and event structure." *University of Minnesota Linguistics Colloquium Series*. University of Minnesota, Minneapolis. November 11, 2022.

Refereed Conference Presentations

"A (de)prepositional approach to directed motion predicates in Cantonese and Hmong" (with Justin Leung). *Theoretical East Asian Linguistics (TEAL-14)*, University of Southern California, Los Angeles. March 19, 2025.

"Parts of speech in Hmong." *Hmong Studies Consortium International Conference*, Merced College, Merced, CA. November 2, 2024.

"Clausal Complementation, Finiteness and Object Control in Hmong" (with Hooi Ling Soh). *Annual Meeting of the Southeast Asian Linguistics Society (SEALS)*, National Tsing Hua University, Hsinchu, Taiwan. June 15, 2024. *Presented by co-author.*

"Directed motion in White Hmong: Serial verb constructions as complex PPs." *Montreal-Ottawa-Toronto-Hamilton Syntax Workshop*, Université du Québec à Montréal. April 23, 2022.

"Verb serialization as event-building: Evidence from Hmong." *Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA)*, Washington, DC. January 9, 2022.

"Nonspecific promises: The Intensional Restitution Effect." *Sinn und Bedeutung*, University of Cologne. September 10, 2021.

"Nonspecific promises: The Intensional Restitution Effect." *Toronto-Ottawa-Montreal Semantics Workshop*, University of Toronto. May 21, 2021.

"Verb serialization as event-building: Evidence from Hmong." *Montreal-Ottawa-Toronto-Hamilton Syntax Workshop*, McMaster University. April 19, 2021.

"Pair-list questions from dependent plurals." *22nd Amsterdam Colloquium*, University of Amsterdam. December 19, 2019.

Refereed Conference Posters

"On the asymmetry between source and goal in complex directional PPs." *Annual Meeting of the North East Lingusitics Society (NELS 57)*, City University of New York. Forthcoming: October 16–18, 2026.

"A thematic approach to Source and Goal paths." *Annual Conference of the Canadian Linguistic Association (CLA). McGill University. June 3, 2025.*

"Diagnosing Prepositions: Decomposing Path in White Hmong." *West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 42)*, University of California Berkeley. April 13, 2024.

"Diagnosing Prepositions: Decomposing Path in White Hmong." *Generative Linguistics in the Old World in Asia (GLOW in Asia XIV)*, Chinese University of Hong Kong. March 6, 2024.

"Culmination entailments in V and P: Evidence from White Hmong." *West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 41)*, University of California Santa Cruz. May 6, 2023.

"Focus, too, and conjunction, too: The syntax and semantics of Japanese *mo*-coordination." *Minnesota Undergraduate Linguistics Symposium*, St. Olaf College. April 13, 2013.

Teaching

Courses

2024	Language Awareness for ESL Teachers (LIN1130) Université du Québec à Montréal
2023	Languages of the World (LING 315) McGill University
2021	Meaning in Language (LING 260) McGill University

Teaching Assistantships

2021	Phonetics (LING 330) Instructor: Connie Ting, McGill University
2020	Meaning in Language (LING 260) Instructor: Bernhard Schwarz, McGill University
2020	Phonetics (LING 330) Instructor: Francisco Torreira, McGill University
2019	Phonetics (LING 330) Instructor: Meghan Clayards, McGill University
2012	Introduction to Linguistics (LING 110) Instructor: Cherlon Ussery, Carleton College

Grading

2020	Structure of a Specific Language - German (LING 410) Instructor: Bernhard Schwarz, McGill University

Awards

2023–2024	Graduate Research Enhancement and Travel Award, McGill Faculty of Arts, $640 Graduate Student Travel Award, Centre for Research on Brain, Language and Music, $700
2022–2023	Graduate Excellence Fellowship, McGill University, $20,000 McGill Linguistics Department Travel Fund, $1,000
2021–2022	Graduate Excellence Award, McGill University, $15,000. Graduate Research Enhancement and Travel Award, McGill Faculty of Arts, $141
2020–2021	Linguistics Department Nominee, McGill Arts Graduate Student Teaching Award Cremona Memorial Fellowship, McGill University, $10,000
2019–2020	Graduate Excellence Award, McGill University, $1,000
2018–2019	Graduate Excellence Award, McGill University, $15,000

Service & Community

Department Organizing

2019–2021	Editor, *McLing* Newsletter McGill University Department of Linguistics
2021	Organizer, Event Structure Reading Group McGill University Department of Linguistics
2020, 2021	Organizer, Accepted Students Open House McGill University Department of Linguistics

Conference Organizing

2023	Workshop on Structure and Constituency in Languages of the Americas (WSCLA 2023)

Reading and Research Groups

2022–Present Community-Engaged Hmong Linguistics Research and Reading Group, University of Minnesota

2020–Present Montreal Underdocumented Languages Linguistics Lab

2018–Present McGill Syntax/Semantics Reading Group

2021 McGill Event Structure Reading Group

Professional Organizations

2024–Present Canadian Linguistic Association (CLA)

2024–Present Generative Linguistics in the Old World (GLOW)

2023–Present Hmong Studies Consortium

2021–Present Linguistic Society of America (LSA)

Outreach

2022, 2023 Panel: "Ask a Grad Student"
Society of Linguistics Undergrads at McGill

2015 Panel: "What paths will a linguistics major take you on?"
Carleton College Linguistics Department

Reviewing

Conference Abstracts: Annual Conference on African Linguistics (ACAL), Canadian Linguistic Association (CLA)

Conference Proceedings: Toronto–Montreal Bantu Colloquium

Non-degree Coursework

2020 Hmong Language Workshop
Southeast Asian Diaspora Project, Minneapolis MN

2013 Denver Publishing Institute
University of Denver

Previous Professional Experience

2014–2018 Financial Advisor
Morgan Stanley Wealth Management, Minneapolis MN